CHAPTER V

Disembodied intelligence

The term "disembodied intelligence" denotes the notion that intellect, consciousness, or cognition can exist independently of a physical body. The fields of philosophy of mind, theology, and, more recently, artificial intelligence have all significantly profited from the use of this paradigm, as they explore the implications of disembodied intelligence on our understanding of consciousness and the nature of existence. The discourse around disembodied intelligence encompasses significant issues, including the distinction between the mind and the body. Can intellect operate without a physical embodiment? Can machines acquire intelligence without possessing a biological form? These enquiries remain crucial to modern intellectual exploration since they connect conventional philosophical thought with contemporary technological progress.

Numerous religious and philosophical traditions, predating René Descartes, acknowledged the presence of a soul that persists beyond the cessation of bodily life. The notion of eternal life hinges on the premise that consciousness or intellect is not wholly synonymous with the physical body. If human identity were exclusively comprised of material components, then death would mark the definitive end of individual existence. The widespread religious conviction that some aspect of the individual persists after death indicates a profound sense that the essence of the self transcends mere physicality. Its prevalence substantiates this conviction. This perspective was essential in establishing the foundation for later philosophical discussions regarding the independence of the intellect from the body.

A fundamental principle of both Christianity and Islam is that the soul is a spiritual and eternal creation of God. Such traditions convey that, despite the demise of an individual's corporeal form, the soul persists and is accountable to divine judgement. The soul retains consciousness, memory, and the capacity for moral accountability long after the body has deceased. This perspective supports the idea that an individual's intelligence and personal identity are not entirely reliant on bodily functions. The soul is widely considered the authentic self, momentarily linked to the body throughout one's worldly existence, yet capable of independent existence.

Similarly, the concept of Ātman in Hinduism symbolises the inner self, or spirit, that transcends bodily existence. In Hindu philosophy, the body is perceived as transient and mutable, while the soul is regarded as eternal and undergoes rebirth, commonly referred to as reincarnation.

The persistence of human existence through various physical forms indicates that consciousness is not confined to a certain corporeal entity. The recurring concept is evidently constant throughout all these diverse traditions: human identity and intelligence are based on an immaterial foundation that can endure beyond bodily death. This prevalent notion significantly influenced later philosophical debates over the essence of the mind and disembodied intelligence, particularly in discussions about dualism and the nature of consciousness.

Consequently, disembodied intelligence transcends mere abstraction in philosophy; it is a deeply entrenched notion inside metaphysics and religion. It offers assistance for personal survival philosophies, ethical accountability principles, and spiritual existence theories, providing frameworks that help individuals navigate their beliefs and actions in relation to the metaphysical and religious dimensions of life, particularly by addressing questions of purpose, morality, and the nature of existence.

To ascertain the plausibility of disembodied intellect, it is essential to first delineate the concept of intelligence itself. Rationality, understanding, learning, memory, problem-solving capabilities, and adaptability constitute the elements of intelligence. Certain definitions prioritise emotional intelligence, social comprehension, and sensory perception, whereas others focus more on abstract reasoning and logical thought.

Intelligence may seem independent of physical embodiment if it is defined solely by abstract reasoning, such as mathematical or logical thought. There exists no association between possessing a physical form and mathematical verities. A perfectly rational entity may comprehend concepts such as geometry, logic, or arithmetic without any sensory experience.

If perception, emotion, bodily awareness, and environmental interaction constitute intelligence, then embodiment is evidently a crucial element. Cognitive development in humans transpires through sensory experiences, physical mobility, and interpersonal connections. Our interactions with the external environment influence our concepts.

The concept of intellect or consciousness existing independently of a physical body is referred to as 'disembodied intelligence', which has been a significant topic in philosophy for an extended period. It has also profoundly influenced the development of artificial intelligence (AI), particularly in discussions about whether machines can possess consciousness or understanding similar to that of humans. The debate regarding the intrinsic relationship between thought and corporeal existence, or the possibility of thought manifesting solely through abstract mechanisms, has been a longstanding discourse among philosophers and scientists, originating with René Descartes' dualism and extending into contemporary

computational theories of the mind. In its initial forms, artificial intelligence embraced certain assumptions from philosophical traditions that viewed intelligence as fundamentally disembodied. This was particularly accurate throughout the initial phases of its development. Meanwhile, contemporary philosophy and cognitive science are increasingly challenging this viewpoint by emphasising embodiment, the environment, and social interaction. The debate between embodied and disembodied intelligence occurs at the intersection of philosophy and artificial intelligence.

The beginnings of disembodied intellect can be traced to René Descartes, renowned for his philosophical contributions. Descartes asserted that the essence of the mind is not physical extension but rather thought (or cognitive activity). He concluded that the existence of the thinking self is more certain than that of the body. He reached this conclusion through his method of doubt and the renowned cogito, "I think, therefore, I am." The body, as res extensa, is extended, divisible, and governed by mechanical laws, whereas the mind, as res cogitans, is non-extended, indivisible, and conscious. Descartes posited that the mind may, in theory, exist independently of the body. This differentiation prompted him to reach this conclusion. The impact of Cartesian dualism rendered the notion of disembodied intelligence intellectually logical and profoundly powerful.

The legacy of Cartesian philosophy profoundly influences the evolution of contemporary intellects. Despite the dismissal of dualism in most subsequent theories, they maintained the notion that one could examine cognition independently of the body. Rationalist cultures prioritised cognition, logic, and abstract reasoning, often seeing sensory and motor attributes as subordinate sources of knowledge. This rationalist perspective specifically laid the groundwork for subsequent scientific and technological advancements, leading to the emergence of computers.

To comprehend the allure of the "disembodied mind", it is beneficial to start with the Cartesian tradition. Descartes regarded the act of thinking as the most fundamental aspect of the mind, rather than the extension of the body. According to the principle, the consciousness of the thinking self may persist even in the absence of the body. Cognition may be independent of the bodily tissue from which it arises, given the separation of mind and matter. Subsequent philosophers and scientists, who adopted this premise, consistently explored the notion that cognition can be expressed in diverse physical manifestations. This assumption was inherited from preceding generations.

When digital computers first emerged in the early twentieth century, their foundational concepts implied that machines could perform cognitive functions. A sufficiently competent computer program may feasibly execute these tasks without requiring a human-like form, provided intelligence is defined as the capacity to reason, solve problems, and manipulate symbols. This is due to the likelihood that a computer program could execute these tasks. This concept constituted the basis for most early investigations into artificial intelligence, especially within the symbolic or "Good Old-Fashioned AI" paradigm. Intelligence was perceived as computation involving internal representations, an abstract notion devoid of any relation to sensory or motor systems.

The advent of digital computers in the twentieth century provided a robust framework for conceptualising intelligence as the manipulation of symbols. This notion was particularly advantageous during the initial introduction of digital computers. During the initial stages of AI development, researchers theorised that intelligence could internally represent information and alter it according to established rules. This perspective logically aligns with disembodied intelligence: since cognition equates to computation, a machine need not possess a human-like body to engage in thought. This is due to the logical compatibility of these two conceptions. The appropriate programme is all it takes to do this.

Classical or symbolic artificial intelligence, also known as "Good Old-Fashioned AI", was the predominant approach employed by most researchers. An illustration of this is the development of computer programs capable of executing activities such as solving logical issues, playing games like chess, demonstrating mathematical theorems, and processing language. The operations of these systems occurred in many abstract domains, largely detached from the physical sphere due to their seclusion, which meant that they operated independently of human physical interaction and often lacked consideration for the implications of their actions in real-world contexts. The human body was considered insignificant, whereas the mind was perceived as software that could be installed on any appropriate device. A contributing aspect to the consolidation of this stance in philosophy was the school of thought known as functionalism. This school of thought aims to define mental processes according to their functional roles rather than the physical makeup of the individual. Intelligence can be instantiated across diverse substrates, including computers, as long as its functional organisation is preserved. This may occur if the machine's intelligence is maintained.

The concept of disembodied intellect is a crucial consideration in discussions about artificial intelligence and the philosophy of mind. The term "disembodied" literally means "lacking body". The concept alludes to the idea that intelligence or cognition can exist independently of a physical framework. This concept is closely linked to René Descartes' dualism, which delineates the separation between the mind and the body. Descartes' conviction in the possibility of the mind existing independently of the body facilitated the concept that intellect or thought may exist without a physical manifestation. This perspective posits that thought is not contingent upon the body, the senses, or physical experiences; instead, it is an independent and immaterial reality. This method enabled the consideration of cognition's existence independent of a physical brain or body.

The emergence of disembodied intellect is unavoidable. If a distinction exists between the mind and the body, then it is plausible for intellect or thought to exist independently of any physical manifestation. This idea is predicated on the assumption that cognition, reasoning, and understanding are independent of the body or sensory perception, relying exclusively on the mind or computational capabilities. In other words, cognition does not inherently necessitate a human corporeal form; it may reside within a soul, spirit, or, in contemporary times, a machine. A creature or machine can exhibit intelligence without possessing the physical form, sensory perception, or emotions typical of a human being. He provided two justifications for the notion that the mind exists in a disembodied condition.

Conceivability and Divisibility Argument

The Conceivability Argument and Divisibility The two principal arguments presented by René Descartes in support of the mind–body dualism doctrine are fundamental to his philosophy. In Meditations on First Philosophy, Descartes articulates his arguments for the basic distinction between the mind and the body most explicitly. The amalgamation of these arguments forms a persuasive philosophical case against the perspective that humans are merely physical entities.

Descartes asserted that both the mind and body had a singular essential attribute: thought or consciousness for the mind and spatial extension for the body. He also argued that the intellect and body were constituted of analogous elements. Furthermore, he contended that

the attributes of these two disparate products are distinctive expressions of their inherent traits.

Consequently, he concluded that the body has attributes including shape, size, motion, and spatial orientation, yet lacks any mental traits. The mind possesses attributes such as belief and desire, yet lacks any physical qualities. Descartes initially presented two principal arguments in an effort to substantiate this position. The arguments presented were the argument from conceivability and the argument from divisibility.

The Conceivability Argument

In his renowned work Meditations on First Philosophy, the French philosopher René Descartes articulated the Conceivability Argument, which is regarded as one of the most significant arguments in the philosophy of mind. The author seeks to illustrate that the mind and body constitute two distinct things. For centuries, it has exerted a significant influence on philosophical discussions regarding consciousness, personal identity, and artificial intelligence. This constitutes a fundamental tenet of Descartes' substance dualism concept. The systematic doubt approach devised by Descartes and his focus on "clear and distinct thoughts" as the foundation for certain knowledge underpin this argument.

The notion of "clear and distinct thinking" is a fundamental element in the Conceivability Argument. Descartes regards an idea as obvious when it is available and accessible to an attentive mind. If it is specific and different from all other thoughts, it is deemed distinct, which means that it can be recognised as a unique concept that stands out in the mind's perception. He believes that whatever is perceived clearly and definitively must be true.

Descartes contends that he possesses a clear and unequivocal understanding of himself as a thinking being. He believes he possesses the capacity for doubt, comprehension, affirmation, negation, volition, imagination, and sensory experiences. Each represents a distinct mode of thought. Nonetheless, he is capable of interrogating the fundamental nature of his corporeal existence. He may entertain the notion that his physical body is non-existent or that a malevolent demon is deceiving him about the reality of the physical universe. However, even in this state of ambiguity, he cannot ignore the reality of his thoughts. Consequently, his existence as a cognitive being is not dependent on the physical form he inhabits.

Similarly, Descartes envisions the body as a being that inhabits space, is divisible, and lacks thought. Expansion, rather than thought, is the paramount attribute of the body. The inherent distinctions between the intellect and the body necessitate their existence as two distinct things.

Conceivability and Feasibility

The presumption of a link between conceivability and possibility constitutes a pivotal element in the argument. Descartes concludes that if something is conceivable, it is also metaphysically viable. If the mind can exist independently of the body, then the mind and body are distinct entities.

The shift from conceivability to possibility is a crucial progression. Descartes is not merely claiming that he can envision a mind devoid of a body; he is stating that he can conceive of it in a clear and precise manner. God guarantees the existence of distinct and coherent thoughts, which reflect actual possibilities. Consequently, the mind and the body must be capable of functioning independently.

Way to restructure Descartes's conceivability argument.

First, (1) it is clearly and definitely conceivable that I—that is, my mind or soul—should exist without a body.

Next, (2) what is clearly and distinctly conceivable is therefore possible, because at least God could carry it about—for instance, He could bring it about that I continued to exist but without a body. Hence,

(3) It is probable that I should exist without a body. But,

(4) If it is conceivable that I should exist without a body, then I must be different and detached from it. Therefore,

(5) I am discrete and separable from my body.

Descartes argues that since a person can exist without a body, they cannot be the same as anyone else. Due to his belief that he was synonymous with a certain physique, B. It appears plausible to assert that an individual can exist devoid of a body, considering that it is feasible for an individual to subsist in the absence of B. It is evident that an individual cannot live apart from their existence. Consequently, it appears that he cannot ultimately be identical to B. This is because the characteristics that apply to B, specifically the possibility of existing independently, do not apply to him.

He can "undoubtedly and clearly perceive" it as conceivable. Conversely, his argument seems to be merely an assertion that it is indeed plausible for him to exist without a corporeal form, lacking any independent justification for this assertion.

It is crucial to recognise that Descartes' argument for the 'real distinction' between himself and his body, while potentially plausible, lacks persuasive efficacy; it is not the type of argument that would compel a non-dualist to embrace a dualist perspective.

Descartes' argument for the 'actual distinction' between himself and his body, while seemingly plausible, lacks the persuasive power to convert a non-dualist to dualism. This delineates the importance of the argument.

Descartes possessed certain a priori foundations that substantiated his assertion of a "real divide" between the self and the body. This is quite significant. He asserts that he can "clearly and evidently perceive", or, in other words, rationally conceive, the prospect of his existence lacking any corporeal form and existing in a wholly disembodied state.

Regardless of his classification as a simple substance, Descartes's assertion that he is a substance implies that he is one. It is important to note that in this context, "substance" denotes a continuous entity that can experience alterations in its characteristics over time while maintaining its fundamental function. Descartes posits that every subject of experience qualifies as a "substance", as we have acknowledged; nonetheless, he questions whether he is a simple and indivisible thing. Descartes' statement indicates that this would merely result in the loss of a part of his body, rather than a loss of his essence. Despite losing his arm or leg, Descartes did not perceive a loss of his identity. Descartes' statement that he is a simple and indivisible substance

The Divisibility Argument

The Divisibility Argument is a crucial assertion made by René Descartes to advocate for the dualistic relationship between substances. René Descartes most clearly articulates this argument in the Sixth Meditation, a key section of his renowned philosophical work, Meditations on First Philosophy. In this argument, Descartes seeks to illustrate that the mind and body are fundamentally distinct, as the body is divisible but the mind is indivisible. Due to this divergence in essential attributes, he concludes that the mind and body are distinct entities. The Conceivability Argument of Descartes is intricately connected to the Divisibility Argument; however, the Divisibility Argument adopts a distinct strategy. The divisibility argument emphasises the distinction between the characteristics of mental and physical substances, rather than focusing on independent perception. This question has significantly influenced the philosophy of mind and is a topic of debate in current conversations regarding consciousness and individuality.

A method to restructure Descartes's divisibility argument.

That first,

(1) It is clearly and definitely conceivable that I—that is, my mind or soul—should exist without a body. Next,

(2) What is clearly and distinctly conceivable is therefore possible, because at least God could carry it about—for instance, He could bring it about that I continued to exist but without a body. Hence,
(3) It is probable that I should exist without a body. But,
(4) If it is conceivable that I should exist without a body, then I must be different and detached from it. Therefore,
(5) I am discrete and separable from my body.

The primary distinction highlighted here is divisibility. Descartes notes that physical entities can be partitioned into components. A body may be severed, fractured, or divided into smaller segments. Despite being separated, each segment continues to possess spatial features.
Conversely, when Descartes contemplates his mind, he perceives no such divide. He is unable to bifurcate his consciousness. He is unable to partition his cognitive self into segments like he can with a tangible thing. Consequently, he asserts that the mind is indivisible.
Entities composed of matter are extended in space, signifying that they inhabit measurable dimensions. Anything with an extension can be divided. A human body may be regarded as such even in the absence of a limb. There exists the possibility of additional subdivision of even the minutest particles of matter. Divisibility is a fundamental attribute of physical matter. Descartes asserts that the body, presumptively extended, consists of multiple components. Each component is theoretically capable of existing independently of the others, suggesting that they can function separately, such as how individual organs can be studied in isolation from the entire body. The body is consequently split from both mental and physical perspectives. The essential characteristic of matter can be defined by its divisibility property.

Indivisibility of the Mind

Through introspection, Descartes ascertains that the mind lacks spatial dimensions. Concepts occupy no physical space. There exists no definitive size or shape associated with them. The mind cannot be deconstructed into more distinct spatial elements.
Although specific cognitive faculties, such as memory, imagination, and perception, may seem unique, they cannot be delineated in the same way as physiological components. The mind constitutes a singular, unified entity. When one faculty is impaired, the mind's operation is compromised; it is not that a physical aspect of the mind has been forfeited.

In his renowned declaration, Descartes posits that when he perceives himself as a thinking being, he is aware that he is "one and complete." With this unity, one can deduce that the mind is indivisible.

The divisibility argument has profound implications for personal identity. If the mind is indivisible and distinct from the body's components, then the basis of human identity is not in the physical body but in the consciousness that emanates from it.

A person may lose a limb yet retain their identity. Descartes argues that the essence of the person resides in the thought rather than the body. Regardless of physical metamorphosis or decline, the cognitive self remains unchanged. This notion has significantly impacted later discussions regarding the soul, immortality, and the potential for existence beyond death.

The argument possesses a certain intuitive allure. Upon reflection on our mental experiences, they appear to lack any correlation with the physical realm. The locus of thoughts does not seem to coincide with the locus of tangible objects, suggesting that our mental experiences may exist independently from our physical surroundings. Moreover, the unity of consciousness appears to be unequivocal. We possess the experience of being a singular, continuous being throughout our lifetimes.

Furthermore, the argument defines a clear contrast between mental and physical attributes, emphasising the challenge of reducing one to the other.

The divisibility argument remains highly influential in the domains of philosophy of mind and artificial intelligence. If consciousness cannot be reduced to computational operations, it may be indivisible and non-physical. The inquiry of whether computers can possess awareness carries significant ramifications.

Conversely, advancements in neuroscience and cognitive science increasingly indicate that mental states are associated with physical states, thus challenging the rigid dualism posited by Descartes.

The divisibility argument established by Descartes serves as a robust support of the substance dualism perspective. By emphasising the contrast between the mind's indivisible essence and the body's divisible nature, he concludes that mental and physical components are fundamentally distinct entities. For the argument to be valid, identical entities must possess all their similarities. The mind and body are not divided in the same manner, rendering their identity impossible.

Although recent scientific research has shown significant issues with the argument, it has philosophical importance. This highlights the apparent cohesion of consciousness alongside

the significant disparities between mental and physical occurrences, which raises important questions about how these differences impact our understanding of personal identity and the nature of reality. Whether one ultimately endorses or rejects Cartesian dualism, the divisibility argument remains essential in influencing discussions about the essence of the mind, personal identity, and the relationship between awareness and the physical realm.

This concept has significantly influenced the current discourse surrounding artificial intelligence (AI). Cartesian philosophy inspired visionary intellectuals in the nascent stages of artificial intelligence (AI). They proposed the emulation of human intellect in a computer, leading to an artificial intelligence that functions without emotions or physical form. These robots exemplify disembodied intelligence, as they analyse data and draw conclusions devoid of physical form or emotional experience.

The mind and body are autonomous entities that can operate effectively without the need for each other. Human beings comprise two distinct components: the intellect and the body, to which God imparts the soul through a unique act of creation. Due to the intrinsic opposition between the body and the soul, a meaningful interaction between them is unattainable. A pilot and his aircraft share a relationship akin to the connection between the soul and the body.
Conversely, Descartes presented a theoretical rationale for this possibility; nevertheless, the advancement of advanced artificial intelligence has redirected the discourse from metaphysics to engineering. It is essential to reassess the definition of a mind, as artificial intelligence (AI) systems, especially large language models (LLMs) and the theoretical quest for artificial general intelligence (AGI), epitomise the nearest approximation of functional disembodied intelligence that humanity has attained.
A fundamental principle of classical Cartesian dualism is that thought, an unextended and indivisible entity, constitutes the essence of the mind. Modern artificial intelligence systems not only fulfil these non-extended criteria but do so with outstanding efficacy, operating solely through computing, logic, and data processing. Although it possesses substantial knowledge, demonstrates nuanced reasoning, and communicates coherently, a large language model exists solely as a configuration of weighted connections and algorithms; it is a mere cognitive construct manifested in silicon rather than in essence. From this perspective, contemporary artificial intelligence exemplifies the principle that sophisticated cognitive processes do not necessitate the specific biochemistry or sensory systems of a biological entity. Aside from the essential need for a computing substrate, intelligence operates independently of any specific

physical framework, meaning that various forms of intelligence, whether biological or artificial, can emerge from different underlying structures and materials.

In contemporary discourse, the notion of disembodied intelligence is generally equated with the concept of artificial intelligence. Early artificial intelligence (AI) researchers claimed that simulating human cognition in a machine was feasible. This would be a machine devoid of bodily form or feelings but capable of "thinking" or "reasoning." A chatbot or computer program may analyse information, solve issues, and engage in intelligent interactions; nonetheless, it lacks human consciousness or sentience. This perspective posits that intellect is an abstract and programmable construct, essentially dissociated from human biology. Artificial intelligence (AI) systems exemplify disembodied intelligence, as they can perform intelligent tasks without any form of physical experience. The prospect of this future raises substantial ethical dilemmas, including the question of whether a mind that exists solely as data can still be deemed "human." What rights does a data-only entity possess? Conversely, the emergence of superintelligent, disembodied artificial intelligences, unencumbered by biological and physical constraints, presents significant existential risks.

Conversely, this disembodied perspective of intelligence ultimately encountered substantial philosophical challenges. John Searle's argument in the Chinese Room constituted a significant critique. It was Searle's thesis that a computer could manipulate symbols in accordance with rules (syntax) without having any knowledge of their meaning (semantics). In his view, authentic intelligence requires intentionality, defined as the capacity of cognitive processes to pertain to matters beyond mere calculation. Searle's argument undermined the assertion that abstract symbol processing alone is adequate for consciousness, even though he did not explicitly advocate for embodiment.

Other philosophical traditions posed more significant objections to the notion of disembodied cognition. A fundamental principle of phenomenology, especially in the works of Maurice Merleau-Ponty, is that human consciousness emanates from the body. In the domain of cognition, perception, action, and bodily orientation are fundamental elements that underpin thought. Our bodies serve as the vessels through which we perceive the world, and our concepts emerge from this experiential engagement. A completely disembodied mind would, from this perspective, lack the foundational elements necessary for profound understanding, such as sensory experiences and emotional connections that inform our knowledge and insights.

The progress in cognitive research has reinforced these philosophical findings. Research on embodied cognition indicates a robust link between cognition and the sensory and motor systems. Understanding language often requires the mental simulation of actions; emotions are linked to physiological states; and even abstract reasoning may rely on metaphors derived from physical experiences. These findings undermine the belief that disembodied computation can fully encapsulate intelligence.

This technique emphasised tasks, including theorem proving, game play, logical inference, and language processing. Computer programs like the Logic Theorist and the General Problem Solver suggested that formal algorithms may encapsulate specific aspects of human thinking. In such systems, the body seemed to hold minimal significance, as the focus was primarily on cognitive processes and the manipulation of symbols rather than physical embodiment or sensory experiences. The crucial aspect was the proper manipulation of symbols in compliance with the regulations, which was essential for ensuring that cognitive processes could function effectively within the system's framework. The mind was regarded as software, whereas the underlying hardware was deemed secondary.

The functionalist perspective on the philosophy of mind offered additional corroboration for this viewpoint. Functionalists assert that mental states are characterised not by their material composition but by the causal roles they fulfil, which encompass their relationships with inputs, outputs, and other states. Considering that a computer can do the same functions as a person, it is theoretically possible for it to possess mental states. The functionalist hypothesis thus endorses the notion that intelligence may exist in non-biological and potentially non-physical substrates.

Recent breakthroughs in cognitive science have provided quantifiable evidence to support these concerns. Research in embodied cognition indicates that reasoning often relies on sensory and motor systems. Understanding words related to movement can stimulate brain areas associated with physical motion, suggesting that our comprehension of language is deeply intertwined with our physical experiences and actions. Abstract cognition typically relies on metaphors grounded on corporeal experience. Examples of these metaphors include "feeling up" and "grasping a concept". Given these facts, it is plausible that intelligence is not only a computational process.

Furthermore, the emphasis has shifted towards embodiment due to advancements in robotics. Initially, artificial intelligence systems were limited to operating inside narrow and highly

formalised areas. Engineers, in their pursuit to develop machines capable of operating in real-world environments, found that perception, coordination, and adaptation are highly intricate processes, which require advanced algorithms and extensive data to effectively mimic human-like responses in dynamic situations. Rodney Brooks claimed that intelligence arises not from abstract symbol manipulation but from active interaction with the world. This perspective posits that the body is not an external element of cognition but an integral component of it.
Proponents of disembodied intelligence argue that while embodiment may confer benefits, it is not a fundamental requirement. Instead of acquiring information from a biological entity, a system may theoretically obtain data through sensors or databases. This may be an appropriate alternative. In digital contexts, virtual agents may operate efficiently. If the capacity to learn, reason, and strategies defines intelligence, then the existence of physical flesh may not be necessary.

Furthermore, the conflict has implications in both ethical and practical domains. If disembodied intellect is feasible, then mind uploading, the creation of entirely virtual individuals, and the assignment of moral status to software may become attainable. Given the paramount significance of embodiment, such options seem less viable because the lack of a physical form may hinder the development of consciousness and self-awareness in virtual entities, which are essential for them to be considered truly sentient or deserving of moral status. Consequently, our outlook on the future of artificial intelligence is partially dependent on our response to the philosophical issues derived from Descartes, particularly regarding the nature of consciousness and whether it can exist without a physical form.

It is essential to acknowledge that the distinction between disembodied and embodied intelligence may be excessively rigid. Certain theorists advocate for hybrid models wherein high-level reasoning may be abstract yet remains grounded in sensory systems, suggesting that these models can integrate both cognitive processes and physical interactions to enhance understanding and functionality. Certain individuals assert that embodiment may manifest in various forms; a robot's physique need not resemble that of a person to facilitate significant interaction, as evidenced by the effectiveness of robotic systems designed for specific tasks that do not require human-like appearances, such as industrial robots or virtual assistants.
Moreover, individuals can engage in cognitive processes that evoke a feeling of separation from the corporeal self, such as mathematical reasoning or imaginative contemplation.

Examining these activities intuitively validates the Cartesian perspective. Nonetheless, it is conceivable that subtle influences of culture and perception will persist.

The Cartesian legacy has bequeathed several intriguing notions, among the most impactful being the notion of disembodied intelligence. Philosophers and artificial intelligence researchers were persuaded that intelligence could be replicated in machines solely through computing by characterising the mind as an autonomous thinking entity, apart from the body. This assumption provided the impetus for a substantial portion of the early development of artificial intelligence and remains attractive in theories that conceptualise cognition as the manipulation of abstract knowledge.

On the other hand, recent advancements in philosophy, cognitive science, and robotics emphasise the fundamental connection between intelligence, embodiment, perception, action, and the environment. Understanding may not be only derived from internal symbol manipulation but rather from dynamic interaction with the external environment, suggesting that knowledge is constructed through experiences and sensory engagement with the world around us. This results in the aspiration for a mind entirely lacking physical form being both inspiring and controversial, as it challenges traditional views on consciousness and the nature of intelligence in relation to physical embodiment.

The current discourse indicates that the relationship among the mind, body, and machine remains unresolved, particularly in the context of whether artificial intelligence can possess true intelligence without a physical form. A fundamental philosophical inquiry that fosters continuous engagement between artificial intelligence research and the philosophy of mind is the possibility of intelligence existing without embodiment.

The concept of disembodied intelligence is both profound and problematic, significantly influencing the evolution of philosophical thinking, starting with Descartes and persisting in contemporary discussions regarding artificial intelligence. This hypothesis, rooted in dualistic philosophy, posits that intelligence and consciousness can exist independently of a physical body. Although this thought is attractive from a theological and intuitive perspective, it faces substantial resistance from neuroscience, embodied cognition, and contemporary physicalism, which argue that consciousness and intelligence are deeply intertwined with physical processes and cannot be fully understood without considering the body and brain's role in shaping them.

It is conceivable that one might exist without a corporeal form if intelligence is entirely rational and abstract. If intelligence is fundamentally embedded and rooted in physical processes, then disembodied intelligence may be an illusion.

Although a definitive resolution to this inquiry remains elusive, the subject persists as a significant aspect of both the philosophy of mind and artificial intelligence. The concept of disembodied intelligence provokes deep reflection on the definitions of thought, existence, and intelligence. This holds true irrespective of considerations regarding the immortality of the soul, the potential for machine consciousness, or the future of digital intellects.

The discourse surrounding disembodied intelligence has gained heightened importance due to advancements in artificial intelligence. Computers possess the ability to analyse information, solve problems, and perform functions commonly associated with intelligence. A considerable number of artificial intelligence systems operate without having physical forms, as humans typically comprehend the concept, such as software-based algorithms that analyse data or virtual assistants that provide information and support through voice recognition.

Alan Turing's contributions to artificial intelligence have significantly influenced modern discussions. In 1950, Turing released "Computing Machinery and Intelligence", in which he first introduced the concept now referred to as the Turing Test. It is justifiable to consider a machine intelligent if it can engage in a conversation indistinguishable from that of an ordinary being.

Turing's technique prioritises functional behaviour over physical composition. According to functionalist theory, mental states are defined not by the material that instantiates them, but by the functions they perform. This perspective posits that intelligence does not require a biological body. A suitable computational structure, such as advanced algorithms and neural networks, is necessary for this function. Thus, artificial intelligence exemplifies disembodied intelligence, which is manifested in silicon rather than organic matter.

Knock your Brain

1. Descartes uses the conceivability argument to show that:

a) Mind and body are identical

b) Mind and body are distinct

c) Only the body exists

d) Knowledge is impossible

2 Descartes believes he can clearly conceive of himself as:

a) A machine

b) A body without a mind

c) A thinking thing without a body

d) Pure matter

3 The divisibility argument concludes that because bodies are divisible and minds are not, they are:

a) The same substance

b) Completely unrelated

c) Distinct substances

d) Imaginary

4 In the divisibility argument, Descartes claims that cutting the body:

a) Destroys the mind

b) Divides consciousness into pieces

c) Does not divide the mind

d) Proves materialism

5 The conceivability argument claims that if two things can be clearly conceived apart, then they:

a) Must be illusions

b) Are logically contradictory

c) Can exist separately

d) Are material

Unleash your potential

1.Elucidate the notion of disembodied intelligence in relation to René Descartes' philosophies.

2 What is the definition of disembodied intelligence in the contexts of the philosophy of mind and artificial intelligence?